

Herrera at Second Base ? Maybe

(Special to the Times-Journal)

CLEARWATER, Fla. — The largest second base candidate in captivity is in camp with the Phillies. He is Pancho Herrera, the 6-foot, 3-inch, 225-pound Cuban who was the Most Valuable Player in the International League last year.

By inclination and habit, Herrera is a first baseman. A very good first baseman. He has sure, soft hands and surprising agility. For that reason, and because 1) he is right-handed, 2) he hit .329 with 37 homers and 128 runs batted in at Buffalo (to cop the Triple Crown), and 3) Ed Bouchee is entrenched on first, Herrera is being given a chance at second.

It would be a revolutionary transition, for second basemen are usually lithe, swift fellows, and their trade is the most complex on the diamond. The other three candidates—in cumbant Sparky Anderson, rookie Bob Malkmus and former Tiger-Red Soxer Ted Lepcio—all fit into that physical category.

Actually, Herrera never played second base before arriving here from a successful campaign in the Cuban winter league (where he won the home run and RBI titles). Because of his big bat, though, the Phillies once entertained serious ideas of transforming him into a third baseman. He was recalled in the last month of 1958 and played 29 games there. He hit .270.



PANCHO HERRERA

"For a fellow who never played the position before," remembers manager Eddie Sawyer, "he did an acceptable job. Last year he was going to play third at Buffalo, but he broke his leg playing in Cuba so he had to be anchored to first. Right now our job is to get him acquainted with a five-fingered glove. Since he's used to the right side of the infield, we'll take a look at him over there first."

Herrera's leg injury has healed completely. He hopes to get down to his 1959 playing weight of 215 in a few weeks, and to his best weight of 205 as the season

wears on. He is eager to cash in on his opportunity.

"I play anywhere," he says. "I like first base, naturally, but I want to make the team, first."

Herrera has surprised skeptics with his nimbleness at second. The first few games he played, intra-squad and exhibition, he handled everything that came his way, even pivoting successfully on a double play.

"There are a lot of things you have to do at second," observes infield coach Andy Cohen, "but you HAVE to make the double play. For such a big guy, Herrera sure has the moves."

If Herrera doesn't make it right away at second, he may become an all-purpose utility man.

"He might play any of the infield positions except short," Sawyer says. "And if he shows anything with the bat, he'll be awfully hard to budge. We can always use runs."

Herrera, 25, claims he is a better hitter than ever, crediting a new, level swing and the patience to wait for good pitches as the solution to previous weaknesses.

"Don't worry about Pancho," Pancho says. "If he gets good chance, he will hit."

The notion entrances Sawyer. "Can you imagine," he says wistfully, "a second baseman batting cleanup?"